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Education

Columbia University Ph.D. Candidate in Economics (BusEc track)	2020 - 2026
Bocconi University M.S. in Economics and Social Sciences, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>	2020
Bocconi University B.S. in International Economics and Finance, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>	2017

Research Interests

Political Economy, Media Economics, Organizational Economics

Job Market Paper

An Image is Worth 1000 Words? Partisanship and Attention in Videos

Abstract: Political news today is increasingly consumed in attention-scarce, video-based environments. Yet existing research on media partisanship remains text-centric and implicitly assumes long-form, attentive processing. This paper studies how partisanship operates in video news through the transmission of multi-modal signals: images and text. I develop a multimodal measure of video partisanship to quantify partisan content in video news and decompose the contribution of each modality. I show that the informational strength of each modality depends on attention: images convey partisanship rapidly through affective cues, while text operates through substantive information that requires sustained exposure to accumulate. A survey experiment using real news footage shows how these properties shape viewers' responses to political videos. Partisan images elicit immediate emotional responses even under brief exposure, whereas partisan text shifts policy attitudes only with sustained exposure. Overall, the results show how low-attention video environments reshape persuasion, by filtering out substantive textual information, and relying mostly on the emotional effect of visual signals. Efforts to improve media quality must account for the asymmetric roles of visual and textual content.

Working Papers

The Mechanistic Fixed-Effects Topic Model: Recovering Corporate Culture from Employee Reviews

with [Dan Biderman](#), [David Blei](#), [Wei Cai](#), [Amir Feder](#) and [Andrea Prat](#)

Abstract: Probabilistic topic models are widely used to uncover latent themes in observational text, but comparisons across groups are vulnerable to environmental variation in language. When documents are generated in different contexts, such as across industries or sentiment polarities, standard topic models conflate contextual differences with topic content, while bag-of-words representations discard contextual nuance. We introduce the mechanistic Fixed-Effects Topic Model (mFETM), an unsupervised generative

model that explicitly separates invariant topic content from environment-specific deviations. To retain context and tone while preserving interpretability, mFETM defines topics as distributions over interpretable semantic concepts extracted from a large language model using sparse autoencoders. Applied to over 900,000 pro and con documents from Glassdoor reviews of S&P 1500 firms across 20 industries, mFETM improves held-out document perplexity while yielding topics that are substantially less confounded by review sentiment and industry vocabulary. In downstream firm-level analyses, mFETM recovers stable dimensions of corporate culture that reliably predict inclusion in Fortune’s 100 Best Companies to Work For. Finally, because the model operates in representation space, steering along estimated fixed-effect directions enables controlled counterfactual generation of workplace text across environments.

With or Without Conditions? Equity-Efficiency Tradeoffs in Municipal Transfers in Brazil

with *Luigi Caloi*

Abstract: To improve service delivery, central governments can tie intergovernmental transfers to local policy performance. While performance-based transfers incentivize local governments and generate efficiency gains, they also shift transfers from low- to high-capacity governments, creating welfare-reducing inequities. We study this equity-efficiency trade-off using a bundle of transfer reforms to Brazilian municipalities. When two states tied transfers to relative educational performance, student test scores rose substantially: moving from the 25th to the 75th percentile of per capita conditional transfers increased scores by 0.16 standard deviations. However, the reform also widened funding disparities across municipalities, which translated into disparities in municipal expenditures in multiple sectors. In contrast, contemporaneous reforms to unconditional transfers had negligible effects on student outcomes. We use a simple model of optimal transfers to interpret these findings. Our results suggest that the introduction of performance based transfers delivered large efficiency gains, limited welfare losses from inequities, and was welfare-enhancing. We find minimal evidence of multitasking distortions or score manipulation. Instead, we document improvements in the quality of education inputs and find suggestive evidence of reduced corruption.

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

CPE Graduate Student Grant Opportunity, <i>Columbia Center for Political Economy</i>	2024
CELSS Seed Grant, <i>Columbia Experimental Laboratory in the Social Sciences</i>	2024
J-PAL’s Jobs and Opportunity Initiative Brazil (with Luigi Caloi), <i>J-PAL</i>	2023
Wueller Fellowship for Best Teaching Fellow (Runner-up), <i>Columbia University</i>	2022
Dean’s Fellowship, <i>Columbia University</i>	2020 – Present

Seminars & Conferences

IOG-BFI Spring Conference, Economics of Media Bias Workshop,	2026
Bocconi AI and Society Conference, CEPR Media Workshop	
AI+Economics Workshop Zurich	2025

Other Research Experience

Research Assistant to Prof. Andrea Prat and Andrey Simonov, <i>Columbia Business School</i>	2021–2024
Research Assistant to Prof. Cailin Slattey, <i>Columbia Business School</i>	2021–2022
Research Assistant to Prof. Thomas Le Barbanchon, Bocconi University	2019–2020
Research Assistant to Prof. Marco Ottaviani, Bocconi University	2019–2020

Teaching Experience

Main Instructor in Math Camp (Economics MA)	2022 – 2024
Guest Lecturer in Political Economy (PhD), Prof. Andrea Prat	2022 – 2024
TA in Industrial Organization (MA), Prof. Ildikó Magyari	2024

TA in Game Theory and Business (MBA), Prof. Andrea Prat	2022 – 2024
TA in Corporate Finance (UG), Prof. Tri Vi Dang	2023
TA in Math Methods for Economists (MA), Prof. Isaac Bjorke	2022

Academic Service

Referee: *Economica*, *Economic Journal*

Bio

Citizenship: Italian
Gender: Male

References

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